

According to statistics reported in the Australian Human Rights Commission's 'Older Women's Risk of Homelessness: Background Paper', women aged 55 and over 'was the fastest growing cohort of homeless Australians between 2011 and 2016, increasing by 31 per cent'.

In other words, financial stress is on the rise both in subsections of our population as well as in growing parts of our population as a whole. That's why bringing awareness to both general stressors and our financial stressors is important, so that, when we are facing tough times or tough moments, we don't simply fall into mindless, default behaviours that negatively affect our finances. Because when we're stressed, we're not generally thinking about cause and effect. Often, we're sabotaging when we're in the midst of it—when it's too hard to think—because we're so freaking stressed. Instead, we think about how we've financially sabotaged after the fact, when we're trying to clean up the mess we made because we were affected by our stressors and behaving in a way that was contrary to the beautiful plans we laid out for ourselves. We're often ashamed of our behaviour so we try not to think about it—other than mentally berating ourselves.

That's why I believe it's vital to develop a series of habits to swap for those stress-related sabotaging behaviours before the stressful situations arise. This may involve creating a series of behaviours that aren't financially related at all, but instead create an environment where you're less stressed overall.

Let's return to the research example with food choice after the participants' hand was in the ice bath. The ice bath had nothing to do with food, but it caused the participants, when they were given a choice of foods, to reach for the unhelpful option. Here, we're acknowledging that there are environments and circumstances that may have nothing to do with our finances that can cause us to be stressed and behave in a way that's not financially helpful. And we want to proactively create different habits and environments to counteract that.

Research supports this approach. A 2016 study by Erik Monasterio, Omer Mei-Dan, Anthony Hackney, Amy Lane, Igor Zwir, Sandor Rozsa and Robert Cloninger, 'Stress Reactivity and Personality in Extreme Sport Athletes: The psychobiology of BASE jumpers'. The researchers chose BASE jumpers because 'extreme sports athletes provide an unusual opportunity